EA Hospitality

Pulse

WEEKLY
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Sunday Foresight

19–25 October 2026

THIS WEEK

Kenya's new US Level 3 will probably outlast its nine Ebola cases: Uganda is still at Level 4, 89 days after declaring its outbreak over

Plus 4 Big Reads and the forecast ledger

EA

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Daily intelligence for city, bush & beach properties across East Africa

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DAILY INTELLIGENCE FOR CITY, BUSH & BEACH PROPERTIES ACROSS EAST AFRICA

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THE SUNDAY FORESIGHT

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EA Hospitality Pulse · Sunday Foresight · Sun 25 Oct 2026

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NUMBER OF THE WEEK

89 days since Uganda declared its outbreak over; the US page still says Level 4.

Every figure in this issue traces to a named, dated source. Claims are graded Confirmed, Reported or Early signal. Corrections are published, not quietly edited.

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THE SUNDAY FORESIGHT · 25 OCTOBER 2026

Kenya's new US Level 3 will probably outlast its nine Ebola cases: Uganda is still at Level 4, 89 days after declaring its outbreak over

The US cut Tanzania to Level 2 on 16 Oct and raised Kenya to Level 3 on 19 Oct; Rwanda is at Level 3 and Uganda at Level 4 (State Department, read 25 Oct). The ratings do not follow the cases. Kenya has nine, in one cluster (MoH, 23 Oct). Uganda has none (20 Oct) yet is at Level 4.

> **WHAT EVERYONE IS MISSING**
>
> : the argument is whether Kenya's outbreak will grow. The better question is how long the rating outlasts it. Uganda declared its outbreak over on 28 July; the US page still read Level 4 on 25 Oct. Its central bank held an emergency meeting on 14 Oct and raised its rate to 12%, citing weaker tourism receipts among other causes. Kenya following suit is our inference.

THE WEEK'S SIGNALS

1 THE US NOW RATES FOUR EAST AFRICAN DESTINATIONS THREE WAYS

Tanzania Level 2, Mtwara aside (16 Oct). Kenya Level 3 (19 Oct). Rwanda Level 3, Uganda Level 4, both issued 4 June (State Department).

So what — know who reads the US page.

City, Bush, Beach · TZ KE RW UG · Confirmed (levels) / Inference (booking effect) · impact:demand

2 UGANDA'S OUTBREAK ENDED, ITS ADVISORY DID NOT, AND ITS CENTRAL BANK CALLED AN EMERGENCY

The Bank of Uganda raised its rate from 9.75% to 12.0% on 14 Oct, the largest move since 2011, citing energy, the shilling and a US$4.6bn current-account gap, partly from lower tourism receipts (Nairametrics, 14 Oct). The shilling is down over 11% since January (Daily Monitor, 15 Oct).

So what — reprice shilling debt; dollar earners feel less local-cost pressure.

Bush, City · UG · Confirmed (rate, figures) / Inference (tourism share) · impact:margin

3 KENYA'S EBOLA COUNT IS NINE, ONE CLUSTER, AND THE FIRST CONTACTS LEAVE QUARANTINE TODAY

Nine cases, two deaths, 135 contacts traced, no community spread or travel restrictions (MoH, 22–23 Oct). Nigeria says its case is closely related to Kenya's index case (Al Jazeera, 23 Oct).

So what — tell guests the screening steps in advance.

City, Bush · KE · Confirmed (statements) · impact:risk

4 TANZANIA'S DOWNGRADE ARRIVED WITH A NEW ENTRY FORM FOR EVERY TRAVELLER

Since 17 Oct every mainland arrival needs an online health form (Travel Advisory No. 18). US$44 insurance applies since 1 Oct. No booking link to the downgrade is yet established (ATTA, 19 Oct).

So what — explain both in your pre-arrival email; hold rates.

Bush, Beach · TZ · Confirmed (rules) / Inference (rate headroom) · impact:watch

5 ZANZIBAR'S TRADE SHOW DREW AN AMERICAN SHARE

Essence of Africa (20–22 Oct) was previewed with 178 buyers from 40 countries, 23% from the Americas (organiser, 15 Oct).

So what — follow up this week.

Beach · TZ · Confirmed (preview figures) · impact:demand

Blind spots: CA/DE/FR Kenya advice, UK Uganda and Tanzania pages, Africa CDC, four gazettes, Kenya's August arrivals.

30/90-DAY DEMAND CALENDAR

KE 25 Oct — first Ebola contacts leave quarantine (MoH). Hold the "one cluster" message.

TZ 9 Nov — Tanzania October CPI (release pattern).

US 12 Nov — CDC entry-order renewal due (our call).

KE 14 Nov — EPRA fuel review. Budget on the current cap.

WLD 30 Nov — EAC visa comments due; our Kenya Level 3 call runs here.

If the rating outlasts the outbreak, which month is your 2027 rate card priced against?



Illustration: Onyango George / EA Hospitality Pulse

BIG READ 1 OF 4 · 19 OCTOBER 2026

The law that reprices every deposit your lodge takes

Treasury and the Central Bank spent the first week and a half of October taking public views on a Bill that rewrites the licensing of every company standing between a guest's card and a lodge's bank account. One of the eleven hearings was held in a hotel. The hospitality industry, which has already been taught once this year what a payment rail costs it, was largely somewhere else.

One of the eleven public forums on the draft National Payment System Bill was held at the Mombasa Beach Hotel, between nine in the morning and one in the afternoon, in a function room of the sort East African hotels rent out for about the price of a mid-season double. The venue was incidental. The subject was not. Somewhere in that building a card terminal was taking a deposit on a December booking, routed through a payment gateway whose right to exist in its current form is exactly what the Bill in the room was proposing to rewrite.

The National Treasury and the Central Bank of Kenya published the draft Bill, alongside a draft National Payment System Policy, on 21 September. The public participation window ran from 28 September to 9 October, across eleven venues from Garissa to Nandi, with submissions accepted by post, by hand at the Governor's office on Haile Selassie Avenue, or by email to paymentslawreview@centralbank.go.ke. The notice was signed by John Mbadi, Cabinet Secretary for the National Treasury. The Bill would repeal the National Payment System Act, Cap. 491A, the statute under which every payment service provider in Kenya currently operates. The window has now closed.

This is the most consequential piece of legislation for East African hospitality that almost nobody in East African hospitality read this month, and the reason is structural. Hotels and lodges are not payment companies. They are merchants. They do not hold a licence from the Central Bank and they will not need one under the new regime either. What they hold instead is a contract with somebody who does, and that contract is about to be renegotiated by force of law.

Consider what the draft actually proposes. It creates ten licence categories, six for payment service providers and four for payment system operators, each carrying a minimum capital requirement set out in the Third Schedule.

Payment initiation and account information services sit at KES 5 million each. Money remittance sits at KES 30 million. Merchant acquiring and electronic wallets sit at KES 50 million. Electronic money issuance, the category into which an operation on the scale of M-Pesa would fall, sits at KES 250 million. On the operator side, payment gateways sit at KES 10 million, payment messaging at KES 20 million, and card schemes and switching and clearing at KES 50 million apiece. An applicant licensed under more than one category would hold the minimum for the highest-capital category plus fifty per cent of the minimum prescribed for the additional one. Clause 78 repeals the old Act outright and clause 79 requires any person providing payment services to comply within one year of commencement. Publication for consultation does not itself repeal anything or validate an existing authorisation, so current holders may have to apply again, and clause 7(7) bars an applicant whose application is declined from submitting another for twelve months.

That last point is where the argument begins, because it meets a market that is smaller and thinner than most operators assume. The Central Bank's own directory of authorised payment service providers, dated 6 November 2025, lists 41 companies. Nine are authorised to issue mobile money. Seven process it without issuing. Three run payment infrastructure. Two are special cases, including the firm that collects parking fees at Kenyan airports. The remaining twenty are authorised for one thing only: operating a merchant payment platform. That bracket contains the names a safari camp or a boutique hotel on Diani actually deals with, including Pesapal, Direct Pay, Kasapay, Zamupay, Tendepay and Dolcepay, alongside the international entrants Paystack, dLocal and Unlimit.

Twenty small-to-middling companies, facing a capital floor, a reapplication and a twelve-month lockout if that application fails, is not a stable field. The predictable outcome is consolidation, and consolidation is where the merchant discount rate lives. A lodge that currently pays a competitive rate because four gateways want its volume will discover what it pays when two do. Nothing in the Bill sets or caps a merchant fee. It requires providers to disclose fees and terms clearly, which is a transparency rule, not a price rule. Operators should read the capital schedule as a forecast of their own cost of acceptance in 2028, and they should read it now, because 2027 rate cards are being signed this quarter.

The sector does not need to be told in the abstract what a payment decision costs it. It has this year's receipts. When the Kenya Wildlife Service moved park entry fees and the rail that collected them, the industry's objection was never mainly about the money. "Our protest isn't necessarily about the increase," Fred Odek, chairman of the Kenya Tourism Federation, said in early October 2025, when the federation went to court over fees announced with two days' notice. On 3 October 2025 the Milimani High Court granted the federation an injunction, Justice John Chigiti issuing a conservatory order halting the increase pending a full hearing. By March 2026 the federation had taken a separate petition on the payment system itself to Parliament, asking lawmakers to reverse the migration away from the old eCitizen platform.

The grievance that followed was specifically about a payment charge, and it is worth quoting at length because it is the clearest statement on record of how this transmission works. By April 2026 operators were objecting to a five per cent gateway fee layered onto park payments. The federation put the cost to the industry at roughly KES 550 million. Operators had been given about 48 hours' notice, and had already published their 2026 rates, so the charge could not be passed to the client and had to be absorbed. "That is not a sustainable situation for businesses operating on thin margins," said Daniel Mbugua, chairman of the Tour Operators Society of Kenya. Odek's complaint was narrower and sharper: "The gateway fee has no receipt." Conservation fees generated one. The payment charge did not, which means it could not be reclaimed, audited, or shown to a client. Kennedy Kaunda, group chief executive of the East Africa Tour Guides and Drivers Association, was blunter about the operational side: "The new KWS payment system is chaotic." The system also offered no provisional holds, which for an industry that books a year out is not a feature complaint but a cash-flow one.

Hold that episode against the draft Bill and the question an operator should be putting to the consultation becomes obvious, and as far as the public record shows nobody from hospitality put it. A safari operator takes a deposit of twenty to thirty per cent at confirmation and the balance thirty to sixty days before arrival. It then disburses that money to lodges, camps, transport and park authorities. For months, it is holding a client's funds on

behalf of third parties. Read clause 4 alongside the definitions beside it and the question stops being rhetorical. The Act applies to any person who acts as a provider "in relation to sending, receiving, storing or processing of payments", and separately to anyone who "owns, possesses, operates, manages a system that facilitates cross-border payments or money remittance services". Money remittance is itself defined as "the acceptance of monies for the purpose of transmitting them to persons resident in Kenya or another country". Clause 9 then sets out who needs no licence, and that list is short and closed: state-owned enterprises, banks, microfinance banks and building societies. The Bill does address customer funds, at clause 36, requiring electronic money issuers and electronic wallet providers to hold monies in trust accounts, with clauses 37 to 40 covering commingling, insolvency and income, and a Fourth Schedule barring those same two categories from holding more than KES 500 million or a quarter of trust monies with a single bank, whichever is higher. Those are the right protections, and they are written for two licence categories a tour operator does not hold. Whether an operator's client account sits inside this perimeter or outside it is a question for the drafters rather than an accusation, and the consultation was the place to ask it.

The scale against which these rules are being written is genuinely large. M-Pesa handled 46.4 billion transactions worth KES 41.7 trillion in the financial year to March 2026, a figure that counts the same shilling more than once as it moves, and held roughly KES 250 billion in customer trust accounts at the last count the Central Bank cited. Nobody designing a payments statute around numbers like those is thinking about a twenty-room camp in Laikipia, which is precisely why the camp should have been in the room.

The cost of the rail, as opposed to the cost of the service, is measurable, and the remittance data make the point with unusual clarity. World Bank figures put the average cost of sending 200 US dollars from the United States to Kenya at 4.26 per cent, against a UN target of three per cent by 2030. Break that down by instrument and it becomes 11.26 per cent for cash to cash and under two per cent for a card or bank-funded transfer into a mobile wallet. The same money, the same corridor, a fivefold difference decided entirely by which pipe it travels down. Kenyan remittances reached a record 451.8 million dollars in August even as the twelve-month total slipped 1.3 per cent, with United States inflows down 12.6 per cent after a one per cent tax on cash-funded transfers took effect in January. David Precious, senior market analyst at EBC Financial Group, warned that higher costs "may push some senders to informal channels", where official data stops seeing them. An operator whose European clients start paying by whichever method is cheapest for them rather than cheapest for the lodge will recognise the dynamic.

None of this is a Kenyan eccentricity, which is why Tanzanian, Ugandan and Rwandan operators should treat the Nairobi draft as a preview rather than a neighbour's problem. Rwanda has run capital floors of this shape since Regulation No. 74/2023 came into force, requiring 300 million Rwandan francs for a large electronic money issuer, 100 million for a smaller issuer or payment aggregator, 50 million for payment initiation and account information services, and 30 million for money remittance. Kenya's proposed numbers sit in the same register. The direction of regional travel is towards fewer, better capitalised, more closely supervised payment companies, and a hotel sector that sells in dollars, collects in four currencies and settles in shillings has more exposure to that shift than almost any other merchant category.

What remains available to an operator is small, specific and worth doing this month. Ask your gateway, in writing, which of the ten categories it intends to apply under and whether it expects to clear the capital requirement. Ask what happens to your settlement timetable if it does not. Get the answer before you sign a 2027 contract, not after. Treat the cost of acceptance as a line in next year's rate build rather than a surprise in a reconciliation. The lesson of the park fee episode was never really about five per cent. It was about the 48 hours, and about who was in the room when the rail was priced. The room was open until 9 October, in Mombasa among other places. It is closed now.



Illustration: AI-generated for EA Hospitality Pulse — synthetic image, not a photograph

BIG READ 2 OF 4 · 20 OCTOBER 2026

Kenya curated 75 experiences this month. Not one of them can be bought where it is displayed.

The Magical Kenya Signature Experiences collection grew to 75 entries on 15 October. The public page carries no price, no availability and no booking button, and Kenya's own draft tourism strategy already names the missing piece.

On the morning of 15 October, in a hall in Nairobi, June Chepkemei read out fourteen names. "We are proud to welcome 14 new experiences into the Magical Kenya Signature Experiences collection," the chief executive of the Kenya Tourism Board said at the unveiling. Among the new entries were a cross-border culinary route and a conservation experience at Ol Pejeta Conservancy, home to the world's last two northern white rhinos. Hawa Ali, who founded the African Food Trail, told the room that "we are moving into a new age in tourism where people want to see more." Enid Nkatha, head of tourism at Ol Pejeta, said she was grateful "that people will now come and help us with conservation work." With the fourteen added, the collection stands at 75 curated entries for the 2026 to 2028 cycle. Chepkemei said the board wanted to back products that are "market-ready, distinctive and capable of delivering."

Five days later, on the morning of 20 October, the collection's public page carried 72 listings. Each one has a title, an operator or venue name, a region, and one or more category tags. Not one carries a price. Not one shows availability. There is no booking button, and no sign in the design of the page that there was ever meant to be one. A handful of the tags are misspelt. The shop window is real, and in places it is beautiful. There is no till in it.

That is not an oversight, and it is worth being precise about why, because the gap between what the programme is and what operators hope it is does most of the damage. Magical Kenya Signature Experiences is a recognition and promotion scheme, and it was built as one. The published programme brief sets out the route in: an operator emails the board's experience team, completes a signed prequalification quiz, then fills in an application form. Eligibility is demanding. The operator must deliver an authentic Kenyan experience, serve international travellers, hold the required licences, have at least two years delivering the product, and be, in the brief's own words, "the provider and point of sale for the customer." It must also have "a website with inspiring content that

lets travelers book," experience of working with international tour operators in the board's key source markets, and must meet export-ready criteria. Later expansion rounds added desk audits and on-site audits to that sequence.

Read that list again and the architecture becomes clear. The state checks that you can already sell before it will agree to display you, and then it displays you. What the designation supplies is promotion: familiarisation trips, exhibitions, collaborative initiatives and training. John Ololtuaa, the tourism principal secretary, put the purpose plainly when an earlier batch took the collection to 61 entries, saying the programme "bridges this gap and addresses the seasonality issues." The board's chairman at the time, Francis Gichaba, said that "through this collection, Kenya has a lot more to offer beyond the wildlife and beach safari."

For one kind of business that is a genuine distribution asset, and the case deserves to be made at full strength. A lodge selling a twelve-night itinerary into Europe is not sold by a website. It is sold nine months out, by a human being at a specialist operator, out of something close to a brochure, after that human being has either visited the property or trusts someone who has. A famil is how that trust gets built, a trade show is where the contracting happens, and export-readiness is exactly the right thing for a national body to be testing at the door. Kenya's draft National Tourism Strategy for 2025 to 2030 still carries an average length of stay target of twelve to fourteen nights. Measured against that model, the collection is correctly built, and the fourteen new entrants have been handed something of value.

Then look at what the fourteen actually are. The categories the board listed are adventure, wellness, culinary tourism, conservation, culture, luxury, family travel, shopping and outdoor recreation. A food trail. A morning spent helping with conservation work. These are not twelve-night products and they were never going to be. They are day-rate and half-day purchases, decided late, very often by somebody who is already in the country, already booked into a camp forty minutes away, and looking at a phone on a Tuesday evening to work out what to do on Thursday. That purchase does not pass across a European tour operator's desk the previous September. It passes through whatever surface the traveller happens to be holding, and it clears or it does not clear in about ninety seconds.

The surfaces that take that purchase have been getting more demanding, not less. On 14 October, the day before the Nairobi unveiling, Booking Holdings launched Vayo, an artificial intelligence travel assistant, in invite-only private beta, with a planned investment of 100 million dollars behind it. Vayo reads confirmations out of a traveller's inbox, assembles them into a trip, then watches the trip for price drops, availability changes, delays and cancellations. For now it books restaurant tables through OpenTable and hands flights and hotels back to suppliers, with transactional booking promised within weeks. Mike Fridgen, its co-founder and chief executive, described the ambition as follows: "Our goal is to provide complete coverage of supply and enable drop-off [to suppliers]." Glenn Fogel, who runs Booking Holdings, said the product "takes a completely traveler-centric approach."

Strip the language back and "complete coverage of supply" is an engineering requirement, not a marketing one. Coverage means inventory a machine can see, price, hold and change. An experience that exists as a page of prose, a region tag and a telephone number is not covered, cannot be covered, and will not be surfaced by anything that has to quote a price to a traveller before it earns a commission. A recognition badge has no application programming interface. The nine hundred words of lovely copy behind each listing are, to that layer of the industry, invisible.

None of which is news to the Kenyan state, and this is the part that should sharpen the argument rather than soften it. The same draft strategy that sets the twelve-to-fourteen-night target also calls, in its own enabling section, for a destination management system "with a booking option" and an online tourism repository intended to work as a one-stop shop. Its strengths-and-weaknesses assessment lists, as a weakness, a "lack of digital tools for seamless tourism services." The diagnosis is the government's own, written down, in a published document. What has been shipped since is display. In December the ministry and the board unveiled a Magical Kenya Souvenir Passport, in physical and digital form, for collecting destination stamps, alongside Hapa Ni Wapi, a

domestic platform showcasing curated packages such as road trips and beach getaways. Rebecca Miano, the tourism and wildlife cabinet secretary, said the passport "will allow both Kenyans and our international visitors to document their stay." Chepkemei said that "by gamifying travel and making it more rewarding, we are promoting tourism while fostering national pride." October's unveiling belongs to the same family. Three windows, no till.

The demand numbers make the omission more expensive, not less. International arrivals reached about 2.79 million by June 2026, an 88 per cent increase on the 1.48 million of 2022, with earnings of 564 billion shillings over the same period, up 110 per cent from 268 billion, figures attributed to the Government Delivery Unit. Kenya is not short of visitors and it is not short of recognition. The 2030 targets, though, call for 5 million arrivals and 1.2 trillion shillings, and the strategy proposes that niche products should make up 35 to 40 per cent of the total product range by then. Niche product is precisely the category where the booking friction is worst, because it is small, perishable, operated by businesses too thin to run their own distribution team, and bought in the last forty-eight hours.

Daniel Mbugua, chairman of the Tour Operators Society of Kenya, told Tourism Update in January that Kenya was facing "product fatigue" in its traditional safari circuits, and characterised 2026 as a "recovery-plus-growth" moment rather than a boom. The fatigue is real and the diagnosis is right. But more product is only an answer to fatigue if the product can be bought, and the state's contribution to the buying is still a line item in a draft.

For the fourteen businesses whose names were read out last Wednesday, and for the sixty-one that were already in, the practical conclusion is unglamorous. The designation is a credential, not a channel, and a credential is only worth what you spend it on. Spending it looks like this: a published price and live availability on your own site, not a contact form; a connection into whichever marketplaces actually sell activity inventory in your market, accepting the commission as the cost of being visible; a product that a guest at a neighbouring lodge can buy on Thursday for Saturday without a phone call; and an honest audit of what the last cycle's familiarisation trips and exhibition stands actually produced in bookings, by name, so that the next ones can be argued for or dropped. If the only measurable output of a national designation is a logo for the website footer and a shared stand at a trade fair, the business has been promoted. It has not been distributed.

The fourteen names in that Nairobi hall were an achievement, assembled by people who built something worth seeing and then passed an audit to prove it. The window Kenya has built for them is the best in the region, and the argument here is not that it should not have been built. It is that the country has now built the window three times in eleven months, each time to warm applause, while the thing a traveller needs in order to hand over money remains unbuilt and, in the government's own paperwork, acknowledged as missing.

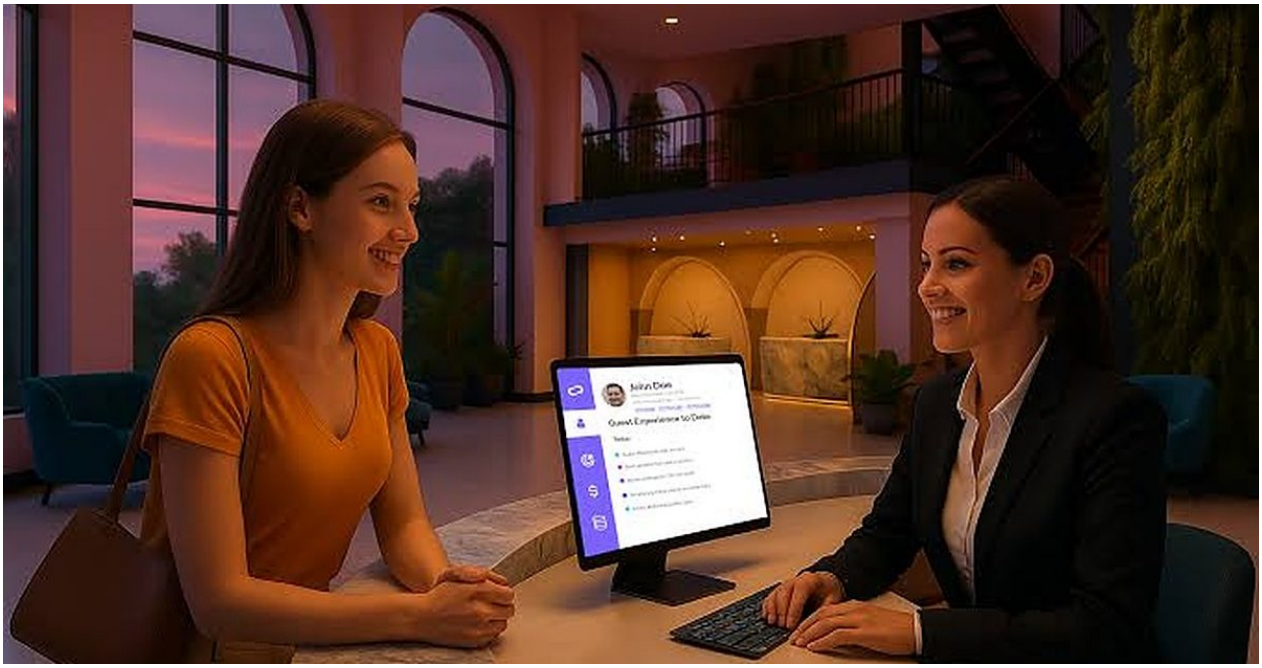


Illustration: AI-generated for EA Hospitality Pulse — synthetic image, not a photograph

BIG READ 3 OF 4 · 23 OCTOBER 2026

Nobody at your lodge decided to block the AI agent. Something in your stack did.

On 18 October an AI agent working for a traveller could not see a rate at a Wyndham hotel. On 19 October it reached the guest details page. Nothing in Wyndham's published policy changed overnight, and that is the point: access to hotel inventory is now decided by bot-management software rather than by anyone's commercial judgement. East African operators have never looked at what their own stack does.

On Sunday 18 October an AI agent acting for a traveller went looking for a room in a Wyndham hotel and never got as far as a price. On Monday 19 October the same agent, pointed at the same chain, reached the guest details page. Nothing in Wyndham's published terms changed in the intervening twenty four hours. No executive signed off a new policy on AI agents over the weekend. What changed was a score, assigned in milliseconds by a piece of bot-management software, about whether the visitor looked like a person.

The tests were run by Terence Ronson, who has spent three decades on hotel technology and runs the Hong Kong consultancy Pertlink. He pointed two commercial AI agents at the websites of the world's ten largest hotel groups on 18 and 19 October, instructed them to behave like a guest, and stopped them short of entering payment details. Readers of his first write-up asked for the evidence, so on 20 October he published the screenshots and the HTTP status codes. Marriott, InterContinental, Accor and Choice let both agents through to checkout on every attempt. Hyatt blocked one agent with an HTTP 429 at a challenge page served by the bot-management vendor Kasada, while the other agent reached the payment screen at Andaz Singapore. Hilton let one agent reach payment three times and handed the other a 502 error. The large Chinese groups, Jin Jiang, H World and BTG Homeinns, sat behind mobile-number logins, SMS codes and apps, which Ronson reads as channel design rather than an anti-agent stance.

"Most of the world's largest hotel groups have not shut out AI agents," he concluded. The more useful sentence is the next one: "Access is often decided by bot-management settings rather than by policy." That is not a story

about hoteliers taking a view on artificial intelligence. It is a story about hoteliers not taking one, and discovering that a vendor default took it for them.

The written record makes the gap plain. On 19 October the agents read the robots.txt files of seven of those groups. Not one names an AI agent in order to block it. Choice and Best Western name AI agents only in order to allow them. Marriott, Hilton, InterContinental, Accor and Wyndham all disallow their search and booking paths to every automated visitor, which on paper is a flat refusal, and the agents walked through anyway. The document that states the policy and the system that enforces one are, in most of the industry, not connected to each other.

That disconnection is not confined to the majors. Nicolas Sitter, who researches how hotel websites are read by machines, parsed the robots.txt files of 105,002 reachable hotel domains across France, Italy, Spain, the Netherlands, the United States, the United Kingdom and Germany. The headline is a near-vacuum: 96.7 per cent carry no AI-specific blocking rule at all, 3.3 per cent block at least one AI crawler, and 0.9 per cent block all of them. "The industry is wide open," he writes. GPTBot is the most-blocked single crawler, at 2.9 per cent of all sites. Where blocking does appear it is rarely a hotelier's choice: France has the highest national rate at 7.5 per cent, and most of that is one cooperative, Logis, which made a single decision for roughly 950 member properties. Strip Logis out and France falls to 2.1 per cent. Sitter's own summary is the line East African owners should sit with: "Most AI blocking is a chain or CMS decision, not an individual hotel decision."

Nothing in either dataset is African. Sitter's seven countries are European and American, and Ronson's eleven groups own almost nothing in Kenya, Uganda, Tanzania or Rwanda beyond a handful of city hotels. So the numbers in this piece do not describe East Africa, and anyone who tells you what percentage of Kenyan lodges block AI agents is inventing it. The measurement does not exist. The mechanism, though, travels a great deal better than the measurement, because the mechanism is a set of vendor defaults, and East African properties run on more vendor defaults than most.

Consider who actually decides whether an agent can see a rate at a camp in the Mara or a lodge on the Nyungwe escarpment. There is the content management system and the company hosting it. There is the content delivery network sitting in front of the site, filtering traffic according to rules written by its own security team. There is the booking engine vendor, whose availability calendar and rate display are loaded into the page from a different domain, often inside a frame, often only after a script has run. Three parties, at least, hold the gate. None of them is the lodge, and none of them has ever been asked what it thinks about agentic travel.

Cloudflare, whose network fronts a very large share of small hospitality websites, changed its defaults on 15 September. It is worth being precise about what it did, because the change has been reported more dramatically than it deserves. Cloudflare now sorts crawlers into Search, Training and Agent categories, and from that date new domains joining the network block Training and Agent bots by default on pages that display advertising, while Search stays allowed. A lodge website carrying no ads is not caught by that clause. Two other provisions bite harder. Non-verified bots remain blocked by default, and an agent browsing on a traveller's behalf without a verified cryptographic signature is, to the filter, a non-verified bot. And from 15 September, crawlers that do several jobs at once are governed by all of their behaviours, so a site that had earlier ticked a box to block AI training, and did not opt out before the deadline, also began refusing crawlers that index for search, Googlebot and Bingbot and Applebot among them. A lodge that wanted to keep its photographs out of a training corpus may have quietly removed itself from search results instead.

The second exposure is worse, and almost nobody in the region is looking at it. Before an agent can be blocked at the door it has to know the door exists, and models learn that the hard way, from crawled text. Sitter checked 108,109 hotel domains against the May 2026 snapshot of Common Crawl, the open web archive that feeds a great deal of model training, and found 39.4 per cent of them absent entirely: not a single page captured. Independents fared better than chains, at 61 per cent captured against 45.9 per cent. What predicted absence was not blocking but obscurity, measured as the number and quality of inbound links. "Being in Common Crawl is necessary but not sufficient for a model to surface you," he writes.

Map that onto the way East African beds have been sold for forty years. Demand arrives through tour operators, ground handlers, safari marketplaces and specialist agents. The itinerary page, the review, the glossy gallery and the inbound link all accrue to the intermediary. The lodge's own domain is frequently a brochure that nobody links to, serving its rates from a third party's script. That is a plausible recipe for a property that is commercially successful and digitally invisible, and it is an argument rather than a finding, because the study that would settle it has not been run in this region. Someone should run it.

None of this removes the commission. This publication argued in September that the agent era moves the shopfront rather than the toll booth, and that remains the case: when an agent books a room it is still usually buying from an intermediary that keeps its margin. Access failure is a separate and earlier problem. It costs you the booking before the price is ever discussed, and it costs it to a competitor whose content delivery network happened to be configured differently.

The honest counterweight is that very few bookings currently ride on any of this. Expedia Group's survey of more than 5,700 adults in the United States, the United Kingdom and India, conducted by YouGov in March and published on 15 April, found 53 per cent comfortable letting AI suggest options, 8 per cent comfortable booking through an AI platform, 68 per cent still preferring to book with a trusted brand even where an AI option existed, and 66 per cent unwilling to let an assistant buy anything on their behalf. "Travelers don't have a technology problem with AI. They have a trust problem," said Xavi Amatriain, the company's chief AI and data officer. On that evidence an East African operator who ignores agent access for another year will probably lose no measurable revenue.

What makes the work worth doing anyway is the asymmetry. Checking costs a morning. Being the one lodge of six that an agent could not read costs the entire booking, silently, with no enquiry in the inbox to tell you it happened. The people building the agents are blunt about the direction. Meta, pressed this month on retailers and airlines whose sites its agent cannot navigate, said that "turning away a personal agent means turning away the customer behind it", and that the fix starts with clear norms. Those norms do not yet exist. Meta, Walmart, Stripe and several others are drafting an open standard for how agents identify themselves to businesses, and until something like it is settled, every site is guessing and every filter is guessing back. Cloudflare, asked by TechCrunch on 6 October how often personal agents are being blocked, said it had no specific data.

There is an irony in the Kenyan position worth naming. In February, at the World Governments Summit in Dubai, Rebecca Miano told a panel that Kenya was "leveraging AI and smart data to personalise the visitor experience" and that the Global South was "no longer a passive player". The state is marketing an AI-mediated destination with some energy. Nobody has yet audited whether the destination's inventory is machine-readable.

The audit is not difficult. Read your own robots.txt and check whether it names an AI agent in order to block one, which it almost certainly does not, and that is the correct answer. Ask whoever runs your content delivery network whether unverified bots are challenged, and what happens to an agent that arrives from a residential network in Frankfurt. Load your own booking page with scripts disabled and see whether a rate is visible without them. Search for your domain in Common Crawl and find out whether a model has ever read your own words about your own property. Then count the links pointing at your site rather than at the operator who sells you, because that number, more than any robots.txt rule, decides whether you exist to a machine.

Four of the eleven groups Ronson tested let both agents through on both days. None of them did it on purpose either. They were simply not blocking, which is a position, but a fragile one, held by default and revocable by a vendor's next release note. The properties that are reachable in 2027 will be the ones that stopped holding it by accident.



Illustration: AI-generated for EA Hospitality Pulse — synthetic image, not a photograph

BIG READ 4 OF 4 · 24 OCTOBER 2026

For fifteen years the guest has paid for Kenya's safari land. Maktau just signed up a second payer.

At a KWS field station in Tsavo West on 21 October, Kenya closed a 160 million dollar Project Finance for Permanence deal covering 17.3 million hectares over ten years. That is about 92 US cents per hectare per year: small against the land, and larger than anything the conservancy model has ever had. The conditions attached matter more than the headline.

Maktau is a gate, not a destination. It sits on the Tsavo West side of the Mombasa corridor, a KWS field station where elephants cross between the national park and the ranchland, the sort of place that appears on an operator's route notes and nowhere in a brochure. On 21 October, Rebecca Miano, Kenya's Cabinet Secretary for Tourism and Wildlife, stood there on behalf of President William Ruto and launched a ten-year programme called Thamani Asili, the value of nature, carrying a headline figure of 160 million dollars, or 20.78 billion shillings.

The press coverage that followed, domestic and international, settled on the number and the hectares. Both are real. Neither is the thing a camp owner in the Mara, a lodge in Laikipia or a tented operation on a Tsavo ranch should be reading, because what was signed at Maktau is not a grant. It is a contract with conditions, and for the first time in the fifteen years that Kenya's conservancy model has existed at scale, those conditions put a payer other than the guest underneath the land that the guest comes to see.

That is the structural fact. Kenya's wildlife business runs on private and community land as much as on parks. The peer-reviewed count, published by Munira Anyonge Bashir and Edwin Wanyonyi in Frontiers in Conservation Science in 2024, put 230 conservancies across 9.04 million hectares, about 16 per cent of the country, with 99 community conservancies accounting for 92 per cent of the area held by association members. Dickson Ole Kaelo, chief executive of the Kenya Wildlife Conservancies Association, now counts more than 230 conservancies across over 10 million hectares, up from 78 in 2013. The land is there. What has never been there is a second revenue line.

"The greatest threat to Kenya's conservancy movement is no longer community willingness," Ole Kaelo wrote this year. "It is finance."

The model as built is elegant and brittle in equal measure. A lodge or camp collects a conservation fee from each guest for each night. That fee funds the lease the conservancy pays the landowner, and the lease is what persuades the landowner not to fence, subdivide, plough or sell. The Frontiers authors describe it plainly: conservancies derive tourism conservation fees that are then invested in social and economic ventures. Strip out the guest and nothing underneath the arrangement holds. In 2020 the guest was stripped out.

What happened next is the best-documented stress test the model has had, and it is worth recalling precisely rather than vaguely. Conservation International's African Conservancies Fund, reporting in July 2023, recorded tourism revenue in the Greater Mara falling by more than 90 per cent, and disbursed over two million dollars in loans between December 2020 and December 2022 to four conservancies, Mara North, Olare Orok, Motorogi and Ol Kinyei, covering 70,000 hectares, which unlocked a further 2.8 million dollars of operational funding. Before the pandemic, the release noted, the landowner and investor relationship was entirely dependent on tourism revenue.

"Support came on time, so we normalized operations as if there were no crisis," said Simon Nkoitoi, senior warden at Ol Kinyei.

Elsewhere in the ecosystem it did not come on time. Daniel Sopia, chief executive of the Maasai Mara Wildlife Conservancies Association, confirmed at the time that investors had cut lease payments by 50 per cent. A 660 million shilling German grant eventually reached 16 Mara conservancies, and Annett Gunther, then Germany's ambassador in Nairobi, was explicit about what the money was for: "We do not want to see people sell their land because of the effect of Covid-19." The emergency was handled. It was handled by philanthropy and a bilateral donor, arriving late, at a scale set by whoever happened to be in the room.

Thamani Asili is the institutional version of that improvisation, and the mechanism is the point. Project Finance for Permanence is a single-close instrument. Enduring Earth, the partnership behind it, founded in 2020 by The Nature Conservancy, The Pew Charitable Trusts, World Wildlife Fund and ZOMA LAB, describes closing as the inflection point when full funding is guaranteed and legal obligations are activated: every financial, legal, institutional and social commitment is secured in one binding agreement, capital is placed in a conservation trust fund, and disbursement is then performance-based, released against measurable outcomes and agreed milestones over a minimum of ten years. Governments do not merely contribute cash. Under the model's government commitment component they make formal policy pledges embedded in laws, regulations or policies designed to persist across administrations, and they undertake to move conservation costs into the national budget over time.

Kenya's half of the money is 80 million dollars, or 10.39 billion shillings, over ten years, matched by 80 million to be mobilised from philanthropy through TNC and Enduring Earth. The donor list runs to dozens of names, including Margaret A. Cargill Philanthropies, the Rob Walton Foundation, the Robert W. Wilson Charitable Trust and the San Diego Zoo Wildlife Alliance. The money is administered by a newly created independent trust, the Thamani Asili Fund for Kenya, which disburses against targets rather than against goodwill. Four landscapes are named: Tsavo to Coastal, Greater Ewaso, Greater Rift to Western, and Southern Kenya, the last of which carries the Maasai Mara and its connection to the Serengeti. Thirty-one counties are covered. The stated outputs are 2.7 million hectares of newly conserved area, 11 million hectares of existing conservation area brought under better management, 6 million hectares where communities are to be equipped to manage land better, about 7,800 direct jobs and 15,000 indirect ones in ecotourism, rangeland work, restoration and carbon, 1.6 million direct beneficiaries, and 7.5 million tonnes of avoided emissions by 2035.

"In Tsavo, conservation is not just about protecting wildlife; it is about protecting a way of life," said Prof Erustus Kanga, director general of the Kenya Wildlife Service. Ruth Masha, TNC's country director for Kenya, framed the design: "We know that when communities lead, conservation can deliver lasting results." Ryan Bidwell, who runs TNC's PFP programme, was blunter about what the money is meant to do, telling Reuters that

there is a substantial gap that would be largely closed.

Here is where an operator should get sceptical, and the arithmetic is the place to start. One hundred and sixty million dollars across 17.3 million hectares over ten years is about 92 US cents per hectare per year. That is not a lease rate, and nobody has claimed it is one. It is a floor: enough to fund management, rangers, planning, enterprise development and a trust fund that can hold the line through a bad year, and nowhere near enough to replace the conservation fee a camp collects at the bed. Anyone reading the launch as relief on their fee schedule has misread it. The guest still pays for the land. What has changed is that the guest is no longer the only thing standing between a landowner and a subdivision.

Two caveats deserve to travel with the number. The first is that the published components do not reconcile cleanly to the headline: 2.7 million hectares of new area, 11 million better managed and 6 million under improved community management sum to 19.7 against a stated 17.3 million, which suggests overlap the launch material does not explain. Until the trust publishes its own baseline, treat the hectare split as indicative.

The second is harder, and it concerns the state's half. Eight million dollars a year, roughly 1.04 billion shillings, is genuinely affordable for the Kenyan exchequer, which is a mark in the programme's favour rather than against it. But the same ministry carries an older promise to the same communities. In November last year, the Wildlife Principal Secretary, Silvia Museiya Kihoro, told the National Assembly's Public Accounts Committee that wildlife compensation claims had reached 3.5 billion shillings with more than 20,000 claims still pending. "We have people who have been waiting since 2014, and it is now 2025," she said. Human-wildlife conflict mitigation is written into Thamani Asili's Tsavo to Coastal workplan. Operators who will be asked by guests, by certification schemes and increasingly by corporate buyers to vouch for the conservation story attached to their bed-night fee should know which part of that story the state has not yet delivered on, and should expect to be asked.

There is also a competitive wrinkle that the launch coverage did not touch. The programme's planned activities include ecological tourism and other nature-based businesses, and 7,800 direct jobs in ecotourism and allied sectors implies enterprise creation, not just ranger recruitment. That means concessional and philanthropic capital building tourism supply inside the four landscapes where existing camps already trade. Over a decade, in a country whose own hotel pipeline debate is about whether East Africa is building faster than it is selling, that is a new variable in the rate card and not only a good deed. Ademola Ajagbe, TNC's regional managing director for Africa, argued at the launch that the programme should be judged by livelihood gains and local opportunity rather than by the size of the fund. Operators should take him at his word and read the enterprise plan as closely as the conservation plan.

None of which argues against the deal. Kenya has roughly 20 to 23 per cent of its land and sea under conservation against a 30 per cent target for 2030, and the World Bank's Nature's Bottom Line, published in March, found 44 per cent of Kenyan GDP comes from sectors highly or very highly dependent on ecosystem services. A ten-year, legally bound, milestone-disbursed instrument is a better answer to that exposure than another emergency grant arriving eighteen months late. It is the third PFP in Africa and the tenth through Enduring Earth, which is to say the model is no longer experimental.

The practical instruction is narrow. If your property sits in Tsavo to Coastal, Greater Ewaso, Greater Rift to Western or Southern Kenya, your landlord's balance sheet is about to acquire a second line, your landscape is about to acquire a milestone schedule written by a trust you did not sit on, and both will shape access rules, lease renegotiations and the conservation narrative you sell for the next ten years. Ask the Thamani Asili Fund for its targets and its reporting calendar now, while the governance is still being built, rather than in year three when the first disbursement review lands. The fee you collect at the bed is no longer the only thing paying for the view. It is still the thing that pays the rent.

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